

Living to 100 is No Longer a Miracle

The most hopeful demographic story of our time



Have you ever wondered what it truly means to live for a century? A hundred years ago, reaching the age of 100 was a statistical anomaly, a feat so rare that it seemed reserved for a fortunate few. Today, however, living to 100 is no longer a miracle. According to the United Nations, there were only **23,000** centenarians worldwide in 1950. By 2024, that number had surged to an estimated **934,776** globally. In the span of a single lifetime, the world has witnessed a **fortyfold increase** in people aged 100 and older.

This remarkable growth continues to accelerate. According to the Pew Research Center analysis of UN data, the world was home to **nearly half a million** centenarians in 2015, more than **four times** as many as in 1990. And the best is yet to come. The United Nations projects that by 2050, there will be an astounding **3.7 million** centenarians worldwide. That is an **eightfold** increase from 2015 levels.

One nation stands as the undisputed capital of longevity. According to data published by Japan's Ministry of Health, Labor and Welfare, Japan recorded **95,119** centenarians as of September 2024, marking the **54th consecutive annual rise**. To put this in perspective, Japan had only **153** centenarians in 1963 when records began. The number surpassed **1,000** in 1981, topped **10,000** in 1998, and exceeded **90,000** in 2022. From **153 to over 95,000** in just six decades, this is nothing short of extraordinary.

The United States tells a similar story. According to the U.S. Census Bureau, there were approximately **2,300** centenarians in America in 1950. By 2010, that number had grown to **53,364**. And according to recent demographic projections, the United States already has about **100,000** centenarians as of 2022. Looking ahead, the U.S. Census Bureau projects that by 2060, America will be home to **590,000** people aged 100 or older. That is nearly **six times** the current number.

Across every data set, one remarkable pattern holds true. According to the U.S. Census Bureau, more than **80 percent** of American centenarians in 2010 were women, with only **20.7 men for every 100 women** in that age group. Japan reports a similar figure, with women accounting for **88.3 percent** of all centenarians in 2024. The oldest living person on Earth, as of 2024, is a **116 year old** Japanese woman named Itooka Tomiko.

Countries worldwide are witnessing this longevity boom. According to the UN Population Division, France had only **100** centenarians in 1900 but reported **31,269** in 2024. Italy grew from **99** centenarians in 1872 to **23,548** in 2025. Thailand now has **45,561** centenarians as of 2024. Even China, despite its relatively younger population, reported **54,166** centenarians in 2013.

Living to 100 was once a headline. Today, according to the UK's Office of National Statistics, **one third of babies** born in the country in 2013 are expected to live to see their **100th birthday**. **What was once a miracle has become the new normal**. The centenarian population is not just growing; it is exploding, and this is perhaps the most hopeful demographic story of our time.

The arithmetic of longevity is clear, but the human work it demands is only beginning. Societies that will host millions of centenarians by 2050 must prepare now. This means investing in geriatric healthcare, designing age-friendly public spaces, supporting caregivers, and building services that address the emotional and social needs of seniors, not just the medical ones. It also means shifting how we think.